PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

How to present — and how to discuss: six minutes, one argument, every member

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Today's puzzle

> Why do some six-minute presentations persuade a room, while others with better research do not?

Halfway through the semester, the problem is rarely the research. It is **design** (what goes in the six minutes), **teamwork** (who carries which part), and **exchange** (what happens in the four minutes after).

Learning goals

By the end of class you should be able to:

1. Explain why **oral advocacy** is a core skill for law school and the profession
2. Build a six-minute presentation around **one contestable sentence**
3. Divide preparation and delivery **evenly** across a team of three to five
4. Design slides that **anchor** speech instead of replacing it
5. **Answer** a question the way an advocate answers a judge
6. **Discuss** another team's presentation as a constructive pre-reviewer

Part 1: Why this matters for future lawyers

Law begins in story

> "The law always begins in story." — James Boyd White

- A brief persuades a reader; **oral argument** persuades a listener who can interrupt you
- The **1L Socratic method** is a cold call with follow-ups. You have been practicing it since September
- **Moot court**, client meetings, firm interviews and hearings all use the same skill: a clear claim, under time pressure, defended under questioning

Public speaking is the one skill machines do not replace. You can have a model draft your outline. You cannot have it stand at the podium and answer a judge.

Our format, in one slide

Element	Rule
Team	3–5 members, one argument
Talk	**6:00 hard stop**, auto-advance
Speaker	Rotates every round
Questions	2–4 minutes: assigned discussant team, then open floor
Scoring	12 team (A–C) · 8 individual (D–E)

Part 2: Design — six minutes, one argument

Start from one sentence

Before any slide exists, the team writes **one contestable sentence**: the claim a reasonable classmate could disagree with.

A topic

"Kenya's electoral system and ethnic politics."

A claim

"Kenya's 2010 county system reduced the stakes of the presidency less than Ghana's party system did, because …"

If the team cannot agree on the sentence, it is **not ready to make slides**.

Structure: tell them three times

Aristotle's rule, as BARBRI puts it: *tell them what you are going to tell them, tell them, then tell them what you told them.*

Segment	Time	Job
Open	0:40	The problem, the pairing, the claim
Body	4:30	Three supports: the round's three requirements
Close	0:50	Claim restated, one implication, the open question

The rubric already asks for **three things per round**. Your body has three parts. That is not a coincidence.

Concede the weak point

> Conceding a weaker point makes your stronger arguments more credible. — David Emanuel KC (via BARBRI)

- Round 3 already requires it: the **rival explanation you rejected**
- Rounds 4–5: the **trade-off** and the **failure mode**
- A team that names its own limitation first **takes the best question away from the audience**

The arithmetic of six minutes

- Speaking pace ≈ **130 words a minute** → about **780 words** in total
- 18 auto-advancing slides × 20 seconds = 6:00 → about **43 words spoken per slide**
- A slide with 100 words of text cannot be read *and* listened to in 20 seconds

Cut until it hurts, then cut one more slide. What you cut goes to the **appendix** for questions.

Part 3: Slides that anchor, not replace

Making great (not good) slides

1. **Figures first, then tables, then text.** People process pictures faster than words
2. **Legible fonts, never the default.** Test from the back row of FO 3.616
3. **One idea per slide**, with a headline that *states* it
4. **Every number carries year, source and caveat**, as the dossier does
5. **Fancy effects sparingly**: use one only when the payoff exceeds what it costs the audience to learn it

Fix this slide

Before

Kenya 2013 Election. The 2013 presidential election in Kenya was held on March 4. Uhuru Kenyatta won with 50.07% of the vote according to the IEBC. The opposition challenged the result in the Supreme Court, which upheld it. This shows that Kenya's institutions …

After

Kenya 2013: the win depended on the denominator

- 50.07% (rejected ballots counted) vs **50.51%** (excluded)
- Threshold: **50% + 1**
- Source: IEBC; Supreme Court petition 2013

The speaker supplies the sentence. The slide supplies the **number the audience must remember**.

Check the number before you cite it

BARBRI repeats a famous claim: meaning is **7% words, 38% tone, 55% body language** (Mehrabian).

- Mehrabian's experiments measured how listeners judged **feelings** from **single words** when tone and words **conflicted**
- He has said himself that the ratios do not apply to ordinary communication
- So: your *words* still carry the argument. Tone and posture decide whether the room trusts you

A cited number that does not say what you claim is the fastest way to lose a judge or a seminar.

Part 4: Teamwork — evenly prepared, evenly shared

One argument, not four segments

The rubric's Criterion C rewards a presentation that sounds like **one mind**. That comes from how the work is divided, not from rehearsing the handoffs.

- **Divide by function**, not by "you take slides 1–5"
- **Everyone can present every slide.** The rotating speaker is a role, not the only person who understands the argument
- **Everyone is ready for questions.** Non-speakers are visibly prepared to support

Roles for a team of three to five

Role	Owns	Combine when the team has 3
Speaker (rotates)	Delivery, signposting, first answer	—
Architect	The one sentence; storyboard; cuts	+ Speaker
Evidence lead	Every number: year, source, caveat	—
Designer	Slides, figures, auto-advance timing	+ Evidence lead
Q&A lead	Anticipated questions; appendix slides	+ Architect

Rotate the roles along with the speaker, so that by Round 5 **every member has done every job**.

A production week

Day	Milestone	Who
Fri	Agree on the one sentence; assign roles	All
Mon	Storyboard: one headline per slide, on paper	Architect
Tue	Draft slides; evidence checked	Designer + Evidence lead
Wed	**Two timed run-throughs**; list of five likely questions	All
Thu	Present; take notes on questions received	All

Part 5: On stage

Delivery

- **Look at the audience**, not the screen. The slides advance on their own
- **State the claim in the first 40 seconds**
- **Stand balanced, vary pace and volume**; pause after the key number
- **Notes, not a script.** Reading aloud loses Criterion D points
- **Never run over time.** At 6:00 the clock stops, and anything after it earns nothing

Answering questions like an advocate

1. **Answer the question actually asked**, in the first sentence: yes, no, or "it depends on …"
2. **Give the reason**, then **the evidence**
3. If you do not know: **say so, and say what would settle it**
4. **Concede and pivot** when the questioner is right
5. **Route to a teammate** by plan, not by panic: "Our evidence lead checked that figure. Maria?"

Part 6: Discussing other teams

How the four minutes work

One team will be assigned to discuss another team's presentation. So, **every non-presenting team is the assigned discussant for one presenting team**.

Minutes	Who	What
0:00–2:00	**Assigned discussant team**	Prepared response
2:00–4:00	**Open floor**	Any member of any team (time to show your **participation**)

Asking good questions counts toward **participation**, not toward the presenting team's grade.

The discussant is a pre-reviewer

The goals, from the conference discussant's role:

- Highlight the study's **relevance and contribution**
- Suggest **constructive ways to make it stronger** before the paper is due
- **Stimulate discussion** with a question the room wants answered
- Benefit **both the presenters and the discussants**: you learn to read an argument critically, which is your next three years of law school

The two-minute discussant template

1. **Restate** their claim in one sentence, at its strongest (steelman)
2. **One strength**, made specific: "The denominator point on slide 6 …"
3. **One question** aimed at a link: claim → mechanism, mechanism → evidence, or evidence → limitation
4. **One suggestion** that names a case, a source or a test

If you cannot do step 1, **your question will miss**. Restating their claim first also shows the presenters that you listened.

Good questions, weak questions

Questions that move the argument

- "What would you expect to see if the **rival** were true?"
- "What does the **comparator** do on this exact rule?"
- "Your indicator is from **2016**. Does the claim survive the newer data?"
- "Which part of the package would **elites capture** first?"

Questions that do not

- "Did you consider culture?" (too vague to answer)
- "Isn't that bad for democracy?" (a verdict, not a question)
- "Can you go back to slide 3?" (unless you say why)
- A two-minute speech that ends with "thoughts?"

What a discussant should not do

From the reviewer's guide, adapted:

- **Do not** criticize harshly or on surface matters: grammar, colors, a typo
- **Do not** insert personal feelings: "I liked it, but …"
- **Do not** give a verdict: "This reform would never pass"
- **Do not** claim superiority: being a senior, a pre-law officer or a native speaker of the focal country's language is not an argument

Be **professional, scientific and constructive**. The aim is to help, not to rank.

Takeaways

1. **One contestable sentence** before any slide
2. **Three supports**, with the weak point conceded before anyone asks
3. **Slides anchor; speech argues.** About 43 words per slide, every number sourced
4. **Divide by function, rotate the roles, rehearse twice against the clock**
5. **Answer first, then give the reason and the evidence**
6. **Discuss as a pre-reviewer:** restate, one strength, one question, one suggestion

Sources

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